

Māra in Early Mahāyāna and the Emergence of *Prajñāpāramitā* Together with an Appendix by Paul Harrison On the Original Language of the *Prajñāpāramitā*

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Abstract:

The first part of this article studies occurrences of Māra in Mahāyāna *sūtra* literature extant in Chinese translation from the Eastern Han period. The second part further investigates one of these texts, the *Prajñāpāramitā* translation extant as T 224, from the viewpoint of its main concern expressed in the rhetoric of emptiness and in the light of circumstances that appear to be relevant to the emergence of this rhetoric, in an attempt to understand its adoption of the *sūtra* format for articulating its message. An appendix by Paul Harrison offers a note on the original language of the *Prajñāpāramitā*.

Keywords:

early Mahāyāna, Lokakṣema, Māra, *Prajñāpāramitā*, *svabhāva*

Introduction

Māra occupies a special position in Buddhist texts. He is ‘Buddhist’ in the sense that, unlike other celestials such as Brahmā, it seems as if Māra may be a specifically Buddhist contribution to the ancient Indian repertoire of heavenly beings.¹ At the same time, however, he is decidedly not ‘Buddhist’ in the sense that, at least during the early stages of his illustrious career, he does not feature as one who considers himself a disciple of Śākyamuni and rather tries to obstruct the Buddhist causes as much as possible. In fact, even though he is clearly a celestial, a *deva*, rather than a denizen of hell, in *Āgama* literature he is usually up to no good at all and in this respect is more of a devil than an angel.

¹ This is not to take the position that Māra emerged without any precedent at all, on which see, e.g., Senart 1882: 169–187, Barua 1915: 195–198, Rao 1954: 243f, Fischer 1980: 91, Karetzky 1982: 77–86, Nichols 2019: 80–101, and on an apparent parallel to Māra in the Jain tradition Marasinghe 2002: 629. A convenient summary has been provided by Seo 1987: 29, in that Māra “doit être lié d’une part à Asura, et d’autre part, surtout, à l’ancien dieu de la mort Mr̥tyu et à Kāma le dieu de l’amour. Cependant, les personnages mythiques ne se développent pas tout seuls dans les airs, ils sont recréés par les hommes pour les temps nouveaux, recevant ainsi un nouvel esprit par leur nouvelle naissance. Māra comme personnage mythologique semble bien s’être développé entièrement dans le bouddhisme, il n’est pas connu dans la mythologie générale indienne.” For monograph studies of Māra see, e.g., Windisch 1895, Ling 1962, Boyd 1975, Clark 1994, and Nichols 2019; on the *Mārasaṃyuktas* extant in Chinese see Choong 2009 and Bingenheimer 2011: 107–150 respectively.

The figure of Māra performs a variety of didactic functions in *Āgama* literature.² In addition to at times serving as a symbol of death or the five aggregates, in his role as an antagonist to the Buddha and his disciples Māra can either exemplify inner struggles or else external challenges for the person he has accosted, in the sense of personifying problems encountered in the ancient Indian setting.³ In view of these multifaceted perspectives, the question naturally arises how this intriguing figure fares in early Mahāyāna *sūtra* literature.⁴

In pursuing this investigation, within the framework of the present study my focus will be on the earliest period of Chinese Buddhist translation activity, namely the later part of the Eastern Han (東漢) period ending in the year 220 of the Common Era. Ān Xuán (安玄) and Yán Fótíáo (嚴佛調) were active during this period, so that their rendering of the *Ugraparipṛcchā* pertains in principle to the category of sources to be examined. Although later versions of the *Ugraparipṛcchā* do refer to Māra,⁵ the same does not hold for their translation extant as T 322. It follows that the mainstay of my research will be translations produced by Lokakṣema and his team,⁶ to be studied together with relevant Gāndhārī manuscripts.

At a still earlier time, several *Āgama* texts had already been rendered into Chinese by Ān Shìgāo (安世高). Here, Māra features four times in listings of various types of humans and celestials,⁷ a typical *Āgama* formulation used to convey that a particular qualification or indication is generally applicable. Moreover, one passage shows Māra gaining dominion over an unguarded mind.⁸ This much of Māra's multifaceted personality had thus already appeared in Chinese translation prior to the texts that I will be surveying below.

I. Māra in Early Mahāyāna

The sequence of my examination of occurrences of Māra in early Mahāyāna *sūtras* whose translation can confidently be attributed to Lokakṣema and his team follows the frequency of references in ascending order, proceeding from the lowest to the highest number of

² My usage of the phrase “*Āgama* literature” comprises Pāli discourses, following a suggestion offered by Skilling 2024: 383.

³ See in more detail Anālayo 2014b: 117–119.

⁴ The present article is part of a wider research project of reading early Mahāyāna *sūtras* from the viewpoint of relevant passages in *Āgama* literature. The limitations mentioned in Anālayo 2025c: 130 apply here as well, in particular in the sense that my ignorance of Japanese prevents me from taking into account the wealth of research published in that language.

⁵ See Nattier 2003: 241, 268, and 296.

⁶ Harrison 2019: 704 points out that “Lokakṣema’s archaic translations are important because, until very recently, they were our oldest surviving evidence for Mahāyāna Buddhism in India (Harrison 1993). While this position has now been usurped by the materials discovered in Gandhari, nevertheless, given the fragmentary nature of most of these Gandhari texts now coming to light, Lokakṣema’s translations are likely to remain an indispensable resource for historical investigations.”

⁷ Examples are T 13 at T I 234b13, 236c14, and 240b3, and SĀ³ 1 at T II 493a29 (on the translatorship attribution see Harrison 2002: 3). T 109 at T II 503c11 is not included in my count of four instances due to its uncertain status; see Nattier 2008: 54f. For the same reason, I have also not included T 397.13 in my survey here or below; see Nattier 2008: 57–59.

⁸ EĀ² 2 at T II 876a12, which is the 11th discourse in the order of the collection reconstructed by Harrison 1997: 269; the parallel AN 3.105 at AN I 262,3 does not mention Māra. Not included in my survey is a reference in T 602 at T XV 170b13–15 to Māra’s army (= objects of the five senses), as according to Zacchetti 2002, 2004, 2010a: 259f, and 2010b this text is a commentary on a translation by Ān Shìgāo that in turn is extant in a manuscript discovered in 1999 at the Kongō-ji (金剛寺) temple in Kawachinagano, Osaka Prefecture, Japan (for more information see <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Kong%C5%8D-ji>); see also the discussion in Deleanu 2003.

occurrences.⁹ With the survey completed, which I have divided into two parts, I will then attempt to evaluate the implications of what has emerged in this way, with a particular emphasis on the earliest completely extant version of the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā* and its adoption of the *sūtra* format to articulate teachings on emptiness.

1.1 Māra in Some Early Mahāyāna sūtras

A single occurrence of Māra features in the first text to be taken up, T 458, for which no Sanskrit title is known. The Chinese title refers to Mañjuśrī, who features twice in the *sūtra*,¹⁰ and in what follows I will refer to T 458 simply as “the Mañjuśrī Discourse.” Harrison (1993: 161f) reports that in this *sūtra* “no bodhisattva takes part, or (with the exception of Mañjuśrī) even appears to be present; the Buddha discusses the career of the Tathāgata, the bodhisattva vow ... and the Mahāyāna with his disciples.” According to the relevant portion of the Mañjuśrī Discourse, being always subject to Māra’s deeds is one of several detrimental outcomes of craving and delight in relation to the five strands of sensual pleasure.¹¹ This presentation is well in line with a role Māra takes in *Āgama* literature as an icon of enjoyment of sensual pleasures.¹²

The next text to be studied is the *Kāśyapaparivarta*. Māra features thrice in the version of this *sūtra* translated by Lokakṣema and his team, T 350. In one of these instances, Śākyamuni explains to Mahākāśyapa that a bodhisattva can go beyond Māra’s realm in four ways.¹³ This explanation forms part of a series of expositions of sets of four. The present set of four comprises not abandoning the aspiration for Buddhahood (*bodhicitta*), remaining free from anger toward people from the ten directions, being familiar with non-Buddhist teachings, and being respectful toward other bodhisattvas. Compared to the previous instance related to sensual pleasures, the role of Māra here evolves by being related more specifically to progress to Buddhahood. Three of the four qualities mentioned in this way are directly relevant to such progress, where *bodhicitta* combines with the absence of anger and the appropriate attitude toward others who are on the same path to Buddhahood.¹⁴ The implication is that a shortcoming in any of these respects, such as, for example, a loss of inspiration to pursue the goal of becoming a Buddha, can be identified as the work of Māra.

The other two references in the *Kāśyapaparivarta* version translated by Lokakṣema and his team occur in the context of an exchange between Subhūti and five hundred monks who

⁹ The search term is 魔, and the searched texts are T 224, T 280, T 282, T 283, T 350, T 362, T 418 (only the prose), T 458, and T 807; see Nattier 2008: 176.

¹⁰ T 458 at T XIV 435b8 and 437b11. In relation to the reference to an inquiry/inquiries by Mañjuśrī in the discourse’s title 文殊師利問菩薩署經, Harrison 1993: 161 notes that Mañjuśrī is “only mentioned twice, and in the third person at that; he certainly never asks any questions.”

¹¹ T 458 at T XIV 437a17: 常在魔事, as a result of the earlier mentioned 愛樂於五所欲.

¹² An example would be SN 5.6 at SN I 132,26, with parallels in SĀ 1205 at T II 328a27 and SĀ² 221 at T II 455c8 (see also Enomoto 1994: 43), where Māra speaks in praise of the possibility of enjoying sensual pleasures as an advantage of being born. In a comment on Māra’s role in *Āgama* literature in general, Bingenheimer 2011: 114 explains that “Māra is the lord of death and desire, and all *saṃsāric* existence is his dominion (*māra-dheyya* or *māra-visaya*). Since early Buddhism was in the main a quest for a way out of *saṃsāra*, Māra tries to disturb the practice of meditation and the preaching of the *Dhamma*, to keep the practitioners within his realm, viz. the *kāmaloka*.”

¹³ T 350 at T XII 190a19: 菩薩有四事出於魔界.

¹⁴ The commended familiarity with non-Buddhist teachings in turn may perhaps be an asset for a bodhisattva’s ability to debate and convert.

had left the site of the teaching due to their lack of understanding and faith in relation to the Buddha's exposition. In the meantime, however, they have become arhats and returned to Śākyamuni's presence. Subhūti now interrogates them, presumably as a way of testing their realization (an interrogation to which I will return below). One of Subhūti's questions is whether they have vanquished Māra, to which they reply that the five aggregates, along with Māra, do not exist.¹⁵ The reference to the five aggregates reflects a dimension of Māra recognized in *Āgama* literature, where he at times simply represents the five aggregates.¹⁶ The idea of the non-existence of both can be appreciated in light of the Sanskrit version, which indicates that both are beyond apprehension.¹⁷ This suggests that the passage broaches a key dimension of the rhetoric of emptiness advocated in *Prajñāpāramitā* literature, in that a *svabhāva* of any dharma cannot be apprehended.¹⁸ In the present context, such an indication would then function as a way for the five hundred to express their insight into emptiness.

Four references to Māra occur in the version of the *Lokānuvartanā-sūtra* translated by Lokakṣema and his team, T 807. One of these concerns the Buddha-to-be seated beneath the tree under which he was to gain awakening. According to the *Lokānuvartanā-sūtra*, on this occasion he emanated a light in order to alert Māra to what was taking place.¹⁹ This depiction can best be appreciated by consulting the *Mahāvastu*, whose close relationship to other parts of T 807 has been documented by Harrison (1982). The *Mahāvastu* reports a *nāga* king noticing that his whole abode is suffused with radiance due to the future Buddha approaching the seat of awakening, and it is right after an eulogy by this *nāga* king that Māra comes flying to the *bodhi* tree.²⁰ Once an exchange with the Buddha-to-be makes it clear that the latter is intent on escaping from his realm, Māra summons his army to launch his famous attack on the eve of the Buddha's awakening.²¹ Thus, from the viewpoint of the narrative denouement presented by the *Mahāvastu*, the Buddha's emanation of light could indeed have alerted Māra to what was about to happen. The *Lokānuvartanā-sūtra* in turn appears to be negotiating the idea that the Buddha could have avoided the whole battle with Māra and his army if he had not, to all appearances, alerted Māra through his display of light. This impression can then presumably be rectified by clarifying that it was deliberate and in conformity with the world that the Buddha displayed the light that alerted Māra.

Another two occurrences in the *Lokānuvartanā-sūtra* combine in the indication that the Buddha can in an instant prevent countless Māras from being able to know where he is, thus he merely displays to people that he is being troubled by Māra.²² The reference appears to be

¹⁵ T 350 at T XII 194a2: 須菩提復問言: 以為降伏魔耶? 五百人復報言: 無有五陰與魔也。

¹⁶ SN 23.11 at SN III 195,6 and SĀ 124 at T II 40b21.

¹⁷ Weller 1970/1987: 1299n8 notes that the reference to not existing, 無有, corresponds to *skandhamārānupalabdhitvāt* in the Sanskrit version (§148); see Pāsādika 2015: 88,2. On a tendency toward literalist readings in T 350 see Anālayo 2025a.

¹⁸ On the rhetoric of emptiness see in more detail Anālayo 2025d: 36–58.

¹⁹ T 807 at T XVII 751c16: 佛道欲成時, 於樹下獨坐, 隨世間習俗而入, 放光使魔知。

²⁰ Marciniak 2020: 481,7 (or Senart 1890: 401,18): *obhāsena sphuṭam sarvaṃ* and Marciniak 2020: 484,14 (or Senart 1890: 404,20).

²¹ A survey of textual accounts and representations in ancient Indian art of this battle can be found in Bautze-Picon 1998; see also, e.g., Malandra 1981, Karetzky 1982: 88–90, Schlingloff 1982, and Guruge 1988/1997: 22–27.

²² T 807 at T XVII 752b16: 佛一念頃能使數千萬億魔不知佛處, 現人為魔所嬈。Guang Xing 2006: 319 and 329n13 understands the present reference to intend the Buddha being tempted by Māra's daughters, on the reasoning that, besides rendering the idea of giving trouble or disturbing, 嬈 can also qualify something as

to Māra causing adversities for the Buddha, such as, for example, when according to one *Āgama* episode he successfully prevented the Buddha from receiving any alms food.²³ Such episodes, the *Lokānuvartanā-sūtra* clarifies, should be understood as a mere show rather than as real adversities.

The last of the four references in this *sūtra* indicates that, although it is so difficult to split the monastic community that countless Māras are unable to accomplish that, the Buddha makes a display to people that the monastic community is being split.²⁴ This must intend the famous attempt by Devadatta to split the monastic community,²⁵ the reality of which the *Lokānuvartanā-sūtra* also puts into question.

The *Lokānuvartanā-sūtra*'s main concern in taking up these episodes would be to provide a docetic reinterpretation of events traditionally associated with the Buddha's life. Māra's role in turn is simply to serve as the Buddha's antagonist, in line with his activities in *Āgama* literature. The distinct perspective that emerges here is mainly to counter the impression that Māra did succeed in creating some difficulties, as these episodes should rather be understood to reflect a deliberate display by the Buddha in order to conform to the ways of the world. Harrison (1982: 212) explains that a central thrust behind this mode of reworking episodes of the Buddha's life and aspects of his conduct is

to show that all these are part of a deliberately fostered illusion of humanity—that the true nature of the Buddha's being and his real attributes are quite different from those which he projects among men in order to further their salvation. Despite all appearances to the contrary, the Buddha remains above this world—he is 'supramundane' or 'transcendent' (*lokottara*).

The next text to be examined is the *Pratyutpannabuddhasaṃmukhāvasthitasamādhī-sūtra*. The version of this text translated by Lokakṣema and his team—T 418, to which in what follows I will refer to as the **Pratyutpannasamādhī-sūtra*—has eight references to Māra. Four of these occur in the verse portions of the text,²⁶ which according to the detailed study by Harrison (1990: 221–249) are from a different translator, wherefore in what follows I will focus just on the other four occurrences.

Two of these four occur in a question asked by the bodhisattva Bhadrupāla about a type of meditation (*samādhī*) that fulfills a broad range of beneficial conditions, a question that serves to motivate the Buddha to teach the *sūtra*. One of these benefits is that all Māras will be unable to shake a bodhisattva who practices this *samādhī*, an outcome the Buddha

charming or enchanting. Yet, according to the *Mahāvastu*'s report Māra's daughters completely failed in charming or enchanting the Buddha; see Marciniak 2019: 367,5 (or Senart 1897: 285,15). The same holds for records of this episode in *Āgama* literature; see SN 4.25 at SN I 127,9 and its parallels SĀ 1092 at T II 287b20 and SĀ² 31 at T II 384a14. Since this is a straightforward success story, there is hardly any need for a *lokottaravāda* reinterpretation. Besides, if Māra's daughters had been intended, a term like 魔女 could reasonably be expected rather than just 魔.

^{23.} SN 4.18 at SN I 114,9 and its parallels SĀ 1095 at T II 288a16 and EĀ 45.4 at T II 772b2. Since this results in the Buddha having to fast even though he had gone out to gather alms food and thus clearly had the intention to eat, this is a good example of an episode that calls for a *lokottaravāda* reinterpretation, wherefore it is no surprise that T 807 at T XVII 752b6 indeed takes up this topic: 佛入城分衛得空鉢出.

^{24.} T 807 at T XVII 752c23: 諸比丘僧難可敗壞, 正使數千億萬魔來及諸惡不能破壞比丘僧, 佛現人破壞比丘僧.

^{25.} For a convenient survey of the main plot see Li 2019: 148–151.

^{26.} These occurrences are T 418 at T XIII 910b3, 912b11, 913b20, and 919a20.

confirms in his reply, resulting in altogether two references to Māra.²⁷ The *samādhi* under discussion has the remarkable potential of enabling a direct encounter with Buddhas of the present, in particular with Amitābha. Śākyamuni explicitly points to recollection of the Buddha as an important supportive condition for this type of *samādhi*,²⁸ which enables relating the above indication to a benefit *Āgama* literature associates with recollection of the Buddha, namely overcoming fear and agitation.²⁹

The third occurrence is part of a set of qualities required of a nun who wishes to set out in the Mahāyāna, one of which is that she should get out of Māra's net.³⁰ The same notion occurs in the version of the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā* translated by Lokakṣema and his team, T 224, to which I will turn in the next section. According to the relevant passage in T 224, bodhisattvas fall into Māra's net when they become conceited on having heard their name announced, and then give up their prior practice.³¹ Such a predicament would also provide a meaningful background to the present reference in the **Pratyutpannasamādhi-sūtra*, in the sense that a nun intent on setting out in the Mahāyāna should shun such conceit and even more so avoid giving up her prior practice. From the viewpoint of *Āgama* literature, it could be added that Māra even tried to catch the Buddha in his snare or net.³² Needless to say, he was unsuccessful.

The fourth reference to Māra in the **Pratyutpannasamādhi-sūtra* features in a *jātaka* tale, where Śākyamuni in a former life as a king heard about a monk who knew the *samādhi* that enables meeting Buddhas of the present. He renounced the throne to go forth under this monk, but even though he served the latter for an exceedingly long time, he never received instructions. This was due to Māra's recurrent interference.³³ This instance is significant insofar as it is the first in the present survey to feature an actual deed by Māra. From the viewpoint of the narrative present in which the discourse is delivered, this deed took place in the past and was directed against the Buddha not in his present life, but rather during one of his past existences.

I.2 Māra in the *Prajñāpāramitā*

In what follows I will refer to the version of the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā* translated by Lokakṣema and his team, T 224, just as “the *Prajñāpāramitā*,” given that the qualification *aṣṭasāhasrika* would only have come into use at a later time.³⁴ With some one hundred and sixty-five occurrences of the term Māra, the *Prajñāpāramitā* emerges as decidedly the most

²⁷ T 418 at T XIII 903b26 and 905a1: 一切諸魔不能動 和 縱一切魔不能動.

²⁸ T 418 at T XIII 904b26: 從念佛因緣, 向佛念. Harrison 1992: 220 explains that the “meditation technique known as the *pratyutpanna-buddha-saṃmukhāvasthita-samādhi*, or ‘*samādhi*’ (‘meditation,’ ‘concentration’) of direct encounter with the buddhas of the present” ... is clearly a developed form of *buddhānusmṛti*.”

²⁹ See Anālayo 2025b: 84n3.

³⁰ T 418 at T XIII 910a22: 出魔羅網去.

³¹ Karashima 2011: 366,5 (= T 224 at T VIII 460c7): 輕易同學人, 自貢高. 彼菩薩用受是字故, 便失其本行, 墮魔羅網.

³² SN 4.5 at SN I 111,28 (= Vin I 20,36), SĀ 1086 at T II 285a6, and SĀ² 25 at T II 381c7; see on the corresponding part in the *Mahāvastu* Charpentier 1909: 34–38 (equivalent to Marciniak 2019: 536,2 and Senart 1897: 415,6) and for the *Saṅghabhedavastu* version Gnoli 1977: 148,21.

³³ T 418 at T XIII 918c21: 於是比丘所一反聞是三昧, 承事師三萬六千歲, 魔事數數起不得一反聞; see also Anālayo 2025c: 121.

³⁴ See the comments in Karashima 2011: 1n1, Zacchetti 2015: 180, and Harrison 2022: 656n13.

prominent arena for his activities among the texts surveyed in this article.³⁵ This holds even when taking into account the fact that this text is substantially longer than any of the other *sūtras* taken up thus far. Adjusting for this difference, the *Prajñāpāramitā* still refers to Māra over four times as frequently as any other *sūtra* whose translation can confidently be attributed to Lokakṣema and his team.³⁶

A one-by-one survey of individual references to Māra, similar to what I have done so far, will of course be impossible for the case of the *Prajñāpāramitā*, wherefore I have to be selective. The first of the many occurrences in this text already exemplifies the basic role of Māra in the *Prajñāpāramitā*. Śākyamuni describes a bad teacher who, due to being influenced by Māra, commends the path of an arhat and Pratyekabuddha over the bodhisattva path.³⁷ Such a way of teaching would of course be fully in line with Māra's intentions. Although in *Āgama* literature his concerns are to thwart any attempt at becoming an arhat, with the dire prospect of a bodhisattva progressing to Buddhahood and then delivering many others, the latter becomes Māra's most pressing concern in the *Prajñāpāramitā*. If a bodhisattva should be successful, many others will also escape from Māra's realm. For this reason, Māra does his best to prevent progress to Buddhahood, compared to which progress to arhat-ship—or to Pratyekabuddhahood, for that matter—is clearly the lesser evil from his perspective.

Elsewhere the *Prajñāpāramitā* reveals that the central agenda of (plural) Māras is indeed to divert bodhisattvas from the path to Buddhahood, so that their progress stalls halfway and they rather become arhats (or Pratyekabuddhas).³⁸ In order to further this agenda, Māra even magically conjures up hells filled with large numbers of bodhisattvas, pretending that rebirth in hell is the destiny of irreversible bodhisattvas.³⁹ Clearly, Māra is up to no good at all.

An in-depth study of Māra in the *Prajñāpāramitā* has already been undertaken by Giddings (2014), who offers a detailed examination and also translates the portrayal of his activities in the ninth chapter, in which Māra is so prominent that he has inspired the chapter's title in several editions of the text.⁴⁰ Among the depiction of the various ways in which Māra obstructs the teachings of the *Prajñāpāramitā*, Giddings (2014: 113) identifies “a gradual serialization in which emphasis changes according to the deepening of the disciples' engagement and understanding.” At the initial stage, such obstructions “begin with doubts over entering the path,” until eventually leading to potential “problems in the relationship between the aspiring bodhisattva and his teacher.”

³⁵ The count of 165 is based on the digital edition by the Chinese Buddhist Electronic Text Association, which per fascicle (fasc.) gives the following count of occurrences of 魔: fasc. 1: 4, fasc. 2: 11, fasc. 3: 2, fasc. 4: 49 (one of which occurs in a chapter title), fasc. 5: 5, fasc. 6: 19, fasc. 7: 28, fasc. 8: 30, fasc. 9: 12, and fasc. 10: 5. Giddings 2014: 108 arrives instead at the assessment that “[t]he text of the *Dàoxíng* contains some one hundred and forty-six references to Māra distributed across ten fascicles.” Perhaps he discounted the one occurrence that features in a chapter title and then confounded 164 with 146.

³⁶ The count of occurrences per fascicle, listed in ascending order, is as follows: T 458: 1, T 418: 2.7, T 350: 3, T 807: 4, and T 224: 16.5.

³⁷ Karashima 2011: 19,9 (= T 224 at T VIII 427b4): 若阿羅漢, 辟支佛道法, 教學是事, 勸, 乃令諷誦。為說魔事, 魔因行, 壞敗菩薩, 為種種說生死勤苦, 言: 菩薩道不可得。是故菩薩惡師。

³⁸ Karashima 2011: 399,9 (= T 224 at T VIII 463c29) reports the reflection of Māras as follows: 當何以使是菩薩便中道取證阿羅漢, 辟支佛道, 莫使成作佛。

³⁹ Karashima 2011: 308,5 (= T 224 at T VIII 454c21).

⁴⁰ Giddings 2014: 112–140 and 248–260. On the chapter's title see the discussion in Karashima 2011: 232n329.

Proceeding beyond the ninth chapter, an entertaining episode in the *Prajñāpāramitā* involves Māra magically transforming himself into the teacher and telling bodhisattvas that what they had earlier heard from him should all be forgotten, as it is all useless.⁴¹ Presumably again in some disguise, Māra even warns bodhisattvas of Māra's affairs. They should understand that the *sūtra* was actually created by Māra. Hence, how could they aspire to become a Buddha (being based) in it, given that it was not taught by the Buddha?⁴² This delightful flourish, which may well be inspired by actual accusations that the *Prajñāpāramitā* should be regarded as the work of Māra, touches on a theme of recurrent importance. Elsewhere in the same text an exposition on rebirth in hell takes up those who consider the *Prajñāpāramitā* not to have been taught by the Buddha and then tell others that they should not train in it.⁴³ In other words, the authenticity of the *Prajñāpāramitā* as the word of the Buddha is of such importance that those who reject it—besides of course being influenced by Māra—deserve to be reborn in hell. I will come back to the topic of authentication later.

The above few selections from the wealth of references to Māra in the *Prajñāpāramitā* show the degree to which the text operates from a perspective of having to confront major and persistent difficulties, identified as the work of Māra. In addition to the vast array of possible problems related to Māra, the *Prajñāpāramitā* also features direct interventions by him. Two such interventions are situated within the narrative time of the tale of the bodhisattva Sadāprarudita, where Māra creates obstructions to the latter's quest to receive teachings on the *Prajñāpāramitā*.⁴⁴ Another such instance occurs at the narrative time when the *Prajñāpāramitā* is being taught. When Māra realizes that the Buddha is surrounded by a large assembly listening to the *Prajñāpāramitā* teachings, he decides to intervene in order to create some disturbance. To achieve this purpose, he mounts a chariot drawn by four horses and gradually drives closer toward the Buddha.⁴⁵

This type of actual interference is in line with interventions by Māra reported in *Āgama* literature, where he also tries to cause disturbances when the Buddha is giving teachings. For this purpose, he transforms himself into an ox on one occasion and into a farmer on another, each time approaching the teaching venue in order to create confusion.⁴⁶ Such acts by Māra are in line with the depiction in other *Āgama* discourses of a variety of hostile attitudes

41. Karashima 2011: 309,4 (= T 224 at T VIII 454c29): 弊魔復化作其師被服, 往到菩薩所, 詭語: 若前從我所聞受者, 今悉棄捨! 是皆不可用也。

42. Karashima 2011: 314,2 (= T 224 at T VIII 455b11): 知: 魔為此事, 魔作是經。云何於中欲得作佛? 是非佛所說 (implementing the removal of an additional 欲 in the query, marked as superfluous by Karashima 2011: 314,3).

43. Karashima 2011: 169,1 (= T 224 at T VIII 441b15): 念是言: 非怛薩阿竭所說。止他人言: 莫得學是!

44. Karashima 2011: 482,7 and 509,1 (= T 224 at T VIII 472b7 and 474b22).

45. Karashima 2011: 82,6 (= T 224 at T VIII 434a2): 弊魔便作是念: 怛薩阿竭, 阿羅呵, 三耶三佛與四部弟子共坐。欲天, 梵天及諸天人悉復在其中。會無有異人, 悉菩薩, 摩訶薩。受決者會當為人之將。自致成作佛。我當行欲壞亂之。弊魔乘一輶之車, 駕四馬, 稍稍前行, 至佛所。Karashima 2010: 37 notes that 弊魔 renders Māra, the Evil One. The more common rendering of *pāpīyān* as 波旬 (see Pelliot 1933) does not seem to occur in Lokakṣema's translations. A related rendering of Māra, the Evil One, in the form of 弊邪 can be found in the counterpart to the above quote in the third chapter of T 225 at VIII 484c1, translated—except for its first chapter; see Nattier 2008/2010—by Zhī Qiān (支謙). Although 魔 does not feature in T 225, the same term, at times combined with 波旬, does occur in several other translations listed by Nattier 2008: 177f as translations by Zhī Qiān; see, e.g., T 6 at T I 180b22, just to mention an occurrence of 魔波旬. As noted by Nattier 2008: 146, “a distinct feature of Zhi Qian's corpus is precisely the variety in his terminology and style.”

46. SN 4.16 at SN I 112,16 and SĀ 1102 at T II 290a16; SN 4.19 at SN I 115,5 and SĀ 246 at T II 59a7.

toward the Buddha and his followers. The didactic function of such Māra episodes would be to inculcate in Buddhist disciples an attitude of composure rather than allowing themselves to be confounded and agitated by whatever adversity they may experience. Although in line with *Āgama* literature and perhaps inspired by some such episode, among the early Mahāyāna *sūtras* surveyed here such a direct interaction with the Buddha stands out for being unique.⁴⁷ This, in a way, adds an additional highlight on the prominence of Māra in the *Prajñāpāramitā*.

In the course of surveying Māra's roles in *Āgama* literature and in the Sanskrit version of the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā*, Nichols (2019: 113) observes that “[t]he level of anxiety inherent in the latter narrative structure is ... much higher, as is the potential attributed to Māra that he can seemingly be anyone, anywhere, at any time.”⁴⁸ The overall perspective that emerges in this way finds an apt reflection in the title chosen by Nichols (2019: 106) for the relevant part of his discussion: “A threat around every corner: Māra in the *Perfection of Wisdom* literature.” Nichols (2019: 112 and 117f) notes that the way Māra features in the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā*

has a decidedly defensive characteristic that creates the perception of a community that perceived itself almost under siege ... the association of Māra with non-Mahāyāna Buddhist rhetoric and opposition to the Mahāyāna and the perfection of wisdom is pervasive in the *Aṣṭa* and evinces an atmosphere of deep insecurity around the community that composed the text ... perhaps the *Aṣṭa* community perceived itself more under siege by criticism from non-Mahāyāna Buddhists and thus called on the symbol of Māra to characterize and turn aside their rivals.

Now, the prominence of the role of Māra in the *Prajñāpāramitā* results at least to some degree from the small size of my sample, as my survey has been confined to occurrences of

⁴⁷ It is unclear to me how Giddings 2014: 108 arrives at the conclusion that in T 224 “there is no single incident in the narrative of the text in which Māra directly intervenes either in the presence of the Buddha or as an ill-willing apparition before any of the attendees in the manner encountered in the earliest stratum of texts” (the last reference is to *Āgama* literature). In relation to the passage quoted in my note 45, he acknowledges that an “event in chapter 3 of the Dàoxíng, does describe Māra preparing to charge the assembly in a chariot drawn by four horses, (434a02) but only as one of a series of ill-wishers towards the Buddha's teaching who become unwittingly thwarted in their plans through the power of Indra simply thinking of *prajñā-pāramitā*.” That Māra eventually drives away due to Śakra's intercession does not change the fact that the episode reports a direct intervention undertaken by Māra in the presence of the Buddha. In fact, Śakra has joined the assembly, together with a large host of celestials, in the evident wish to hear teachings on the *Prajñāpāramitā*. At the present juncture, Śakra recognizes that the person who approaches driving a chariot with four horses is Māra, who has come to confuse the members of the audience. This implies that Māra has already been successful in creating some distraction, as Śakra is now paying attention to him instead of listening to the Buddha teaching the *Prajñāpāramitā*; see Karashima 2011: 83,5 (= T 224 at T VIII 434a7) 釋提桓因作是念: 弊魔乘四馬之車來, 欲到佛所. 是弊魔車馬, 無異 ... 是弊魔所作. 晝夜弊魔常索佛便, 常亂世間人. To this extent, Māra's intervention has even been successful, even though he then has to depart in defeat.

⁴⁸ Another function of Māra in the same text is, according to Nichols 2019: 107, “to establish the importance, even vital necessity, of the teaching of the Perfect Wisdom by describing how bitterly Māra opposes it ... [t]he vehemence of Māra's hostility, therefore, puts the perfection of wisdom forward as all the more precious.” Moreover, according to Nichols 2019: 108 the employment of Māra “might simultaneously have served as an exhortation to more strenuous effort on the part of those in the community. Since Māra will be watching one's every action and step along the path of study in the perfection of wisdom and bodhisattvahood, even greater exertion should be put forth in this practice.” In relation to possible renegades, Nichols 2019: 115 reasons that the *sūtra* can rely on “the figure of Māra to explain that the defectors were weak-willed dupes of the Evil One, bolster the prestige of those who continued and endured his pernicious power, and possibly insulate the group from further attrition: after reading this text, would not a bodhisattva wavering in his practice wonder if his doubts were really real or really Māra?”

Māra in texts whose attribution to Lokakṣema and his team is firmly established. Exploring the present topic further could take place by broadening the textual basis considered for study. This leads me to the versions of the *Drumakinnararājapariprcchā-sūtra* and *Ajātaśatrukaukṛtyavinodanā-sūtra* extant as T 624 and T 626, whose relationship to Lokakṣema and his team is more tenuous compared to the *sūtras* taken up above.⁴⁹

The former of the two indeed features an episode in which Māra directly interacts with Śākyamuni. Toward the end of the *sūtra*, Māra tells the Buddha that the latter's former teachings to *śrāvakas* did not make him afraid or worried. But on hearing the Buddha's present teaching to bodhisattvas, Māra has become highly worried and sorely aggrieved, to the extent of asking the Buddha not to teach in this way again. The Buddha responds by comforting Māra, telling him that he should no longer cry and be worried.⁵⁰ The Buddha then takes up a bit of earth with his fingernail to illustrate those who have faith in his present teaching, whereas those who have no faith in it are like the whole Earth. On account of that, the Buddha concludes, Māra should rather be happy.

This delightful episode involves a significant reversal of Māra's role compared to the *Prajñāpāramitā*, while at the same time delivering the same basic message. Māra is present in the assembly but to all appearances is unable to implement any of his usual mischievous deeds. In fact, he is so aggrieved by what he has to witness that all he can do in his newly acquired helplessness is to beg the Buddha not to give such teachings anymore. His grief throws into relief the superiority of the present teachings over those formerly addressed to *śrāvakas*, which Māra now reveals never really worried him. Similar to the *Prajñāpāramitā*, the basic message is still that lack of faith in the *sūtra* is on the side of Māra. However, rather than being framed as a stern warning, this message finds expression in the Buddha comforting Māra, a charming innovation. Instead of being aggrieved, Māra should find consolation in the knowledge that only few will have faith in what the Buddha has just revealed, comparable to a bit of soil taken from the Earth.⁵¹

The tendency toward a domestication of Māra that emerges in this episode becomes even more prominent in an episode that comes into view on briefly broadening the textual basis even further by proceeding to translations from the period of the Three Kingdoms (三國), in particular those related to the translation activities of Zhī Qiān (支謙).⁵² According to the

^{49.} Both pertain to the category of a “third-tier text” in the detailed analysis of translatorship attributions provided by Nattier 2008: 85, in the sense of bearing only a distant relationship to the style of Lokakṣema and his team; see also Radich 2026. Regarding another potential candidate for inclusion in the present study, T 313, Nattier 2008: 85 reports that this text “abounds in non-Lokakṣema translation terms to a greater extent than any of the other titles reviewed” at this point in her study, including T 624 and T 626, and “[t]his vocabulary is used consistently throughout the text”; see also Radich 2026. Nattier 2008: 86 adds that the translation terminology used in T 313 is close to the terms employed in the verse portion of T 418, which I have excluded from my survey. The same thus necessarily applies to T 313, in that I had to exclude this text from my study. This decision does not have any further effect on the present topic, however, as T 313 does not report a direct action by Māra situated at the narrative time of the *sūtra* being spoken.

^{50.} T 624 at T XV 367a21: 聞是甚愁, 甚憂, 從今已去莫復說是。佛謂魔: 莫復啼哭, 亦勿致愁。

^{51.} The simile as such occurs also in *Āgama* literature; see, e.g., SN 56.51 at SN V 459,15, SĀ 442 at T II 114a22, and SHT III 890, Waldschmidt, Clawiter, and Sander-Holzmann 1971: 139f.

^{52.} A tendency toward domestication is also evident in the taming of Māra by Upagupta reported in the *Divyāvadāna*, Cowell and Neil 1886: 360,14, as a result of which Māra promises that he will no longer trouble Buddhist monastics; see also, e. g., Duroiselle 1904, and Bloss 1978: 162–173. The general trend that emerges in this way has been succinctly articulated by Tian 2023: 181, in that “Māra gradually develops from being the opponent of the Buddha to his follower.”

version of the *Vimalakīrtinirdeśa* rendered by him into Chinese, T 474, Māras are actually bodhisattvas whose activities serve to liberate sentient beings.⁵³

All of this is a far cry from the anxieties that surround the role of Māra in the *Prajñāpāramitā*. This is, in fact, the crucial issue. The example of the *Drumakinnararāja-paripṛcchā* extant as T 624 shows that a direct interaction with the Buddha is not necessarily decisive, and the same holds for the frequency of Māra's occurrences.⁵⁴ In addition, the type of attitude and the concerns articulated by Māra are significant factors to be taken into account. In the case of the *Prajñāpāramitā*, his role clearly reflects a deep-seated and pervasive anxiety regarding the reception and transmission of its teachings.

II. The Emergence of *Prajñāpāramitā*

The highlight on the exceptional role of the *Prajñāpāramitā* that materializes from exploring occurrences of Māra in early Mahāyāna *sūtras* invites taking a closer look at its emergence. Although from the viewpoint of the progress of my research this second part of my discussion is a result of the first part, I need to acknowledge that the two topics explored in the two parts of this article are distinct. Whereas the first part shows the gradual acculturation of Māra to a Mahāyāna context, the second part is instead about the circumstances that appear to have influenced the emergence of the *Prajñāpāramitā* as a *sūtra*. In pursuing this topic, I first turn to the presence of anxieties in the *Prajñāpāramitā* in general and then to the setting within which it appears to have evolved. In combination, what emerges in this way affords a perspective on a possible rationale informing the *Prajñāpāramitā*'s adoption of the *sūtra* format as an integral part of its main message.

II.1 Anxieties in the *Prajñāpāramitā*

Articulations of anxieties and references to fears and uncertainties are a recurrent topic in the *Prajñāpāramitā* even apart from any reference to Māra. Two examples occur right at the outset of the *sūtra*. The Buddha has just invited Subhūti to expound the Perfection of Wisdom for the sake of the great assembly of bodhisattvas present on this august occasion. Subhūti is not able to start right away, however, because first of all he has to clarify doubts that have arisen in Śāriputra's mind on hearing the Buddha's invitation. These concern whether Subhūti is going to comply in reliance on his own understanding—which would imply that an arhat gives teachings on the bodhisattva path of which he could not have personal experience—or rather in reliance on the Buddha's power (*anubhāva*). Subhūti clarifies that his exposition will be based on the Buddha's power.⁵⁵

In addition to clarifying Śāriputra's doubts, the indication given by Subhūti also touches on the need to authenticate the *Prajñāpāramitā* as a teaching given by the Buddha, already mentioned above. Once the latter's power stands in the background of what Subhūti says, his

⁵³ T 474 at T XIV 527c22: 賢者, 十方無量無央數魔魔怪, 賢者, 悉行恐怖。立不思議門菩薩者, 常解度人。 In its narrative context, this is an explanation given by Vimalakīrti to Mahākāśyapa. Nichols 2019: 122 comments that with “[t]his shocking revelation” Māra becomes “a bodhisattva himself, albeit undercover, playing a role as the Evil One in a truly impressive display of skillful means” (the sequence of the two quotes has been reversed).

⁵⁴ T 624 has twenty-five occurrences in its three fascicles and thus 8.3 occurrences per fascicle. Although falling short of the 16.5 occurrences per fascicle in T 224, it clearly comes closer to it than the other texts in my Māra sample; see above note 36.

⁵⁵ Karashima 2011: 2,7 (= T 224 at T VIII 425c13); see also Anālayo 2025d: 34 and 324n141.

words effectively become *Buddhavacana*.

This could be related to *Āgama* literature with the help of the report in a Pāli discourse that a monk—who in the narrative setting had given a teaching on his own accord and was then asked if what he had taught was from the Buddha—explained that whatever is well spoken is all the word of the Buddha.⁵⁶ In its contextual setting, this statement serves as an expression of humility by pointing to the Buddha’s wisdom as the ultimate source for what the monk had been teaching. The same statement, however, clearly admits different readings, and this statement can be read as endowing the notion of the word of the Buddha with a considerable degree of malleability.

In the *Prajñāpāramitā*, Subhūti next gives his first emptiness teaching on the inability to apprehend a bodhisattva, which he immediately follows up with a reference to the need for a bodhisattva not to become afraid on hearing this teaching, a need also reflected in the *Gāndhārī* parallel.⁵⁷ Similar references recur in later parts of the *Prajñāpāramitā*. These thereby touch on another possible source of anxiety, as the rhetoric of emptiness can be unsettling to those who are unfamiliar with it.

This can be explored further with comments by several scholars. As already pointed out by Harrison (1978: 39f), “the philosophy of the *Prajñāpāramitā* ... attacked the qualified realism of the prevalent Sarvāstivādins and held that all dharmas ... are essentially empty (*śūnya*) and devoid of objective reality or ‘own-being’ (*svabhāva*).” Gethin (1998: 236f) adds that the concern of *Prajñāpāramitā* literature is to articulate “the emptiness of all things that we might be tempted to think truly and ultimately exist of and in themselves. To see any dharma as existing in itself is to grasp at it, to try to hold on to it.” Williams (1989/2009: 50) notes that, from this perspective, “the analysis commonly associated with the Abhidharma had ended too early, and thus such a *prajñā* was a defective *prajñā*, not the perfection of *prajñā*,” the last being, of course, “the principal concern of the Perfection of Wisdom texts.” In fact, besides being indeed the principal concern of the *Prajñāpāramitā*, echoes of the same perceived need to articulate the rhetoric of emptiness also occur in other texts translated by Lokakṣema.⁵⁸

⁵⁶. AN 8.8 at AN IV 164,7: *yaṃ kiñci subhāsitaṃ, sabbaṃ taṃ tassa bhagavato vacanaṃ* (correcting the PTS edition’s *tan* to *taṃ*). According to Bodhi 2012: 1791n1627, this statement “expresses the idea that whatever good teachings the disciples speak, even when they themselves have originated them, can be regarded as *buddhavacana* because they are based on the Buddha’s own teachings.”

⁵⁷. Karashima 2011: 4,2 (= T 224 at T VIII 425c23): 菩薩聞是, 心不懈怠, 不恐, 不怯, 不難, 不畏. Similar reactions are depicted in the *Gāndhārī* version, Falk and Karashima 2012: 34: *saye he bosisatvasa eva + + + + [u]vadiṣamaṇa cito ṇa oliati ṇa viparaprītibhavati ṇa samtraso avajati*; see also Falk and Karashima 2012: 42 and 50 for further references to fearful reactions.

⁵⁸. In relation to T 350, the *Kāśyapaparivarta*, Zürcher 1991: 299 notes that this *sūtra* is “about the Bodhisattva career and the doctrine of emptiness.” He summarizes the contents of T 458 in turn—which I have baptized as the Mañjuśrī Discourse—in the following manner: “Exposition on the stages of the Bodhisattva career, explained in terms of the doctrine of universal Emptiness.” In the case of T 418, the **Pratyutpanna-samādhi-sūtra*, Harrison 1998/2018: 5 notes that a “distinguishing feature of the *Pratyutpanna-samādhi-sūtra* is its attempt to reconcile the vision of the buddhas and buddha-fields of the present (and the goal of rebirth in them) with the insights of the Perfection of Wisdom (*Prajñāpāramitā*) school” being “scrupulous about setting the experiences of the meditator against the yardstick of *śūnyatā*, ‘emptiness’,” and thereby in several respects being “very much in the style of the Perfection of Wisdom (*Prajñāpāramitā*) sutras.” In a comment on T 807, the *Lokānuvartanā-sūtra*, Harrison 1982: 212 in turn reports that in the second half of the text “one finds expressed a doctrinal standpoint very similar to that of the early *Prajñāpāramitā* as set forth in the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā*, a standpoint which insists upon the ‘emptiness’ of all dharmas.” Moving beyond my sample of *sūtras* in which Māra makes an appearance, one of three texts that thanks to Nattier 2005 we know to be parts of a proto-

Schopen (1989: 135n5) points out that the “repeated emphasis on fear, terror or dread in connection with hearing the Perfection of Wisdom being taught or explained would seem to indicate that the authors of our texts were clearly aware of the fact that what they were presenting was above all else potentially terrifying,” in the sense “that a predictable reaction to it was fear.” His remark occurs in a note on a reference to fear in the Gilgit manuscript of the *Vajracchedikā*, introduced by Schopen (1989: 95) as “a fine example of what a *Prajñāpāramitā* text in Sanskrit prose actually looked like in the sixth or seventh century.” Thus, fearful reactions on hearing *Prajñāpāramitā* teaching continue to be reported in *Prajñāpāramitā* literature of later times; they are not confined to the *Prajñāpāramitā* translated by Lokakṣema and his team and its Gāndhārī parallel.

In relation to a defensive attitude generally evident in the *Prajñāpāramitā* and the **Pratyutpannasamādhi-sūtra* translated by Lokakṣema and his team, Harrison (2023: 119) comments that “we might imagine that the movement was not yet well established, and therefore, not surprisingly, on the defensive. But what is interesting is how long this marginal rhetoric is maintained.” Harrison (2023: 120f) then offers the following assessment:

we could infer from it that followers of the Mahāyāna went on being despised and mocked for hundreds and hundreds of years. But we should at least consider the possibility that such passages reflect a fossilized attitude, a classical scriptural trope which may once have corresponded to actual social circumstances, but is now repeated even when it no longer reflects reality. If this is the case, it would mean that the presence of such passages in sūtras and commentaries may have no value as evidence of the historical background against which they were composed, and that they are as unreliable an indicator of the actual circumstances of their authors as are the references to the last days of the Dharma, also a fossilized trope. After all, although we would expect such statements from a despised and marginalised newly emergent subgroup, is it likely that a group can remain despised and marginalised—and still survive—for so many centuries? It may well be, however, that even a successfully established community might still have had recourse to this kind of rhetoric for its own purposes, and we might ask ourselves what those purposes might have been. It is conceivable, then, that followers of the Great Vehicle liked to think that the Dharma was always in its last days, and the Mahāyāna was always despised, even when the contrary was clearly the case, when the monasteries in which Mahāyānists were well represented were populous and wealthy institutions, when commentators confidently cited Mahāyāna scriptures as authorities, and, for all we know, rulers with pretensions to bodhisattva-hood sat upon the throne.

The proposed reasoning could well explain the continuity of relating *Prajñāpāramitā* teaching to anxiety and fear, given that by the sixth or seventh century the rhetoric of emptiness could reasonably be expected to be no longer a novelty, wherefore an anticipation of such reactions seems somewhat less pertinent than in the case of the *Prajñāpāramitā* translated by Lokakṣema and his team. In the latter case, however, the rhetoric of emptiness can reasonably be expected to be sufficiently novel to many in the audience to warrant anticipating reactions of fear. Perhaps references to such fear had become so much part of the lore of *Prajñāpāramitā* that they just continued to be repeated even when such reactions were

Buddhāvataṃsaka indicates that everything is empty, comparable to the creation of an illusion; see T 283 at T X 455b1: 諸所有皆虛空, 譬如作幻耳 (another relevant instance would be T X 455c8+10: 諸法皆虛空 ... 諸法譬若幻所化). Even the *Sukhāvatīvyūha*, T 362, has a brief instance of the rhetoric of emptiness; see T 362 at T XII 303c28 and Anālayo 2025c: 128n87.

no longer as prominent as they presumably were in earlier times. In fact, even in later times such references would fulfill a function by bestowing an air of heroism on all those who do not succumb to fear. In other words, once the novelty of the challenging teachings on emptiness has worn off and it seems probable that the majority of members of the audiences will no longer be shocked on hearing the rhetoric of emptiness, those who believe in it may still feel valued and confirmed by their own courageous acceptance of this rhetoric if they hear/read anticipations of fearful reactions.

II.2 The Concerns of the *Prajñāpāramitā*

Unlike expressions of fear in later specimens from the *Prajñāpāramitā* textual family, it seems fair to assume that anxieties evident in the *Prajñāpāramitā* translated by Lokakṣema and his team indeed reflect an environment that was not necessarily welcoming of its main message.⁵⁹ In exploring this environment, it needs to be acknowledged, as pointed out by Hartmann and Melzer (2025: ix), that “[w]e know next to nothing about how the works that are later summarised under the generic term ‘Mahāyāna sūtras’ were created.” Without in any way intending to pretend certainty of ‘knowledge,’ perhaps in the case of the *Prajñāpāramitā* at least the situation may be a bit more promising compared to the case of many other Mahāyāna sūtras.⁶⁰ According to Bronkhorst (2018: 124), “the ‘Perfection of Wisdom,’ which is the subject matter of the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā* ... only makes sense against the background of the overhaul of Buddhist scholasticism that had taken place in Greater Gandhāra during the last centuries preceding the Common Era,” since “[i]t was in Greater Gandhāra, during this period, that Buddhist scholasticism developed an ontology centred on the lists of dharmas,” with the eventual result that “[t]hey looked upon the dharmas as the only really existing things.”

The relevance of the suggested background finds corroboration on consulting the parallel to the *Prajñāpāramitā* extant in a Gāndhārī manuscript from the so-called Split Collection, which refers to the five aggregates being devoid of *svabhāva*.⁶¹ Regarding this manuscript, Falk (2011: 20) reports that a “comparison with the Chinese translation of Lokakṣema ... shows a development from a simple to a more developed text. The Gāndhārī text looks archaic and is less verbose than what Lokakṣema translated.” In their edition of the Gāndhārī manuscript, Falk and Karashima (2012: 20) add that “Lokakṣema ... translated a version already slightly enlarged in comparison to our manuscript, so that our manuscript can be regarded as representing the forerunner to the one Lokakṣema knew.”

Salomon (1999: 179) explains that “Gandhāran Buddhism of the first and second

⁵⁹. Schopen 2000/2005: 9 comments on expressions of defensiveness in Mahāyāna literature in general that “those who do not accept the Mahāyāna are said to be not only ‘stupid,’ but also defective, of bad karma and evil, or even possessed by Māra ... calling those who do not share your conviction ‘stupid’ occurs largely in the face of a rejection that itself threatens that conviction and reflects a certain desperation. More self-confident movements are by definition more assured of their means of persuasion and do not commonly indulge in this sort of thing. Sociologists, however, who have studied sectarian groups in a variety of contexts have shown that this sort of characterization is typical of small, embattled groups on the fringes or margins of dominant, established parent groups” (the sequence of the two quoted passages has been reversed).

⁶⁰. It may be pertinent to note here that T 224 already employs the term *mahāyāna* and is allocated to the category of Mahāyāna sūtras in ancient Chinese catalogues; see Anālayo 2025d: 283f and 409n762. Thus, at least in this case an application of the generic term Mahāyāna sūtra seems justified.

⁶¹. Falk and Karashima 2012: 52: *ruo yeva ausa śariputra virahido ruasvabhavaṇa eva vedaṇa saṃñña saṃkhara viñāṇo + + + + [ri]putra virahido viñāṇasvabhavaṇa*.

centuries AD ... developed an extensive and distinctive textual and intellectual tradition,” and it seems fair to suggest that the *Prajñāpāramitā* would have evolved in dialogue with aspects of this distinctive tradition. In fact, early *Prajñāpāramitā* literature was not necessarily groundbreaking in articulating criticism of Sarvāstivāda doctrinal tenets.⁶² Such criticism can be seen in a Gāndhārī manuscript from the British Library collection studied and edited by Cox (2025), which in terms of dating appears to be earlier than the Split collection manuscript of the *Prajñāpāramitā*.⁶³ This text takes the form of a polemic debate, similar in nature to the Theravāda *Kathāvatthu* and the Sarvāstivāda *Vijñānakāya*. In the course of refuting the standard Sarvāstivāda position that everything exists, the proponent in this exegetical treatise argues that this tenet conflicts with the Sarvāstivāda notion of *svabhāva*.⁶⁴

At the same time, however, the *Prajñāpāramitā* translated by Lokakṣema and his team explicitly announces its own appearance in the south of India after the final Nirvana of the Buddha, from where it will proceed to the west and only then to the north.⁶⁵ According to an explanation offered by Lamotte (1944/1981: 25n1), this reference may carry a symbolic meaning, in the sense of expressing the success of *Prajñāpāramitā* in gradually spreading throughout all of India. After having arisen in the east—presumably due to being delivered by the Buddha at Mount Vulture Peak in Magadha, which is thus the geographical location from which the prediction is formulated—it follows the trajectory of the sun, a precedent explicitly recognized in the **Mahāprajñāpāramitopadeśa*.⁶⁶

^{62.} A reference to *svabhāva* as presumably a notion to be overcome features also in a Mahāyāna *sūtra* preserved in the Bajaur Gāndhārī manuscript 4v11, Schlosser 2022: 130. The same manuscript also refers to obtaining the perfection of wisdom in a context that has just mentioned the first resolve (for awakening) and subsequently indicates that the seat of awakening and other places are empty; see fragment 4r15–16 and 4r18, Schlosser 2022: 124: *paḍhamacitupade ca vrude prañaparamida ca paḍiladha* and *boṣimaḍe śuñe i(*m)e ca (*a)ñā ca deśa śuñā*. Moreover, two related manuscripts each have a reference to not coming from anywhere and not going anywhere; see fragments 6r7 and 11v19, Schlosser 2022: 142 and 146: *akuhicaagamaṇaakuhica-gamaṇa*. This suggests some intriguing affinities with the main concern of the *Prajñāpāramitā*.

^{63.} On the dating of the Split collection manuscript of the *Prajñāpāramitā* see Falk 2011: 20; on the dating of the British Library Kharoṣṭhī manuscripts in general see Salomon 1999: 141–155. Regarding the present manuscript, Cox 2025: 255 reports that, from a paleographic perspective, samples taken from this text “do not deviate significantly from the forms typical of those of other BL [=British Library] scribes whose manuscripts have been assigned to the likely date of the first half of the first century CE.”

^{64.} Cox 2025: 180: *sarvatra sarva(*m a)sti di, tena cakhāḍana ruvāḍana neraīyabhav sarvabhav asti, peyala svabhav parabhave asti, parabhava svabhav asti*. Cox 2025: 181 explains that this is one of the undesirable conclusions depicted by the Gāndhārī proponent, in that if “everything exists everywhere,” then “the material-form sense sphere [exists] in the visual sense sphere; all natures exist in the nature of a hell-being,” and “other-nature exists in intrinsic nature; intrinsic nature exists in other-nature.” Cox 2025: 182–184 explains that “[f]or the Sarvāstivādins, the various categories of existent factors are discriminated from one another on the basis of each factor’s ‘intrinsic’ or ‘self-nature’ (Skt *svabhāva*). In fact, the term Skt *svabhāva* acquires its distinctive function as the invariable determinant of existent factors precisely in this context of the proper classification of factors through this process of inclusion on the basis of the contrast between ‘intrinsic nature’ (Skt *svabhāva*) and ‘other-nature’ (Skt *parabhāva*).” In this way, “the Gāndhārī proponent contends that if, as the Sarvāstivādins maintain, ‘everything exists everywhere,’ the clear demarcation between intrinsic nature and other-nature breaks down; in other words, intrinsic nature would exist in other-nature, and vice versa. Accordingly, the declaration, ‘everything exists everywhere,’ would contradict the very principle of inclusion that is the cornerstone of their own taxonomy of existent factors.”

^{65.} Karashima 2011: 225,5 (= T 224 at T VIII 446a29): 恒薩阿竭去後, 是般若波羅蜜當在南天竺. 其有學已, 從南天竺當轉至西天竺. 其有學已, 當從西天竺轉至到北天竺. 其有學者, 當學之. In discussing this passage, Karashima 2013: 180f and Walser 2018: 233f seem to be unaware of the explanation offered by Lamotte 1944/1981: 25n1, also found in Lamotte 1954: 385–389.

^{66.} T 1509 at T XXV 531b6: 後般若波羅蜜從東方至南方, 如日, 月, 五星, 二十八宿, 常從東方至南方, 從南

As Étienne Lamotte also points out, the idea of such a progression can already be found in descriptions of the wheel-turning king in *Āgama* literature, whose conquest of the whole world takes the form of his wheel treasure proceeding from the east to the south, the west, and then the north.⁶⁷ On the reading that emerges in this way, leaving aside for the time being variations in the parallels,⁶⁸ the prediction in the form given in the *Prajñāpāramitā* translated by Lokakṣema and his team regarding its own spread in India does not have to be taken literally and could be read as carrying mainly a symbolic sense.

II.3 The *Prajñāpāramitā* as a *sūtra*

Whatever may be the final word on the significance of the *Prajñāpāramitā*'s prediction of its own spread, based on what has emerged so far it seems possible to propose a perspective on the *sūtra* format adopted by the *Prajñāpāramitā* for articulating its teachings. Catering to the needs of bodhisattvas is clearly the most central concern throughout the rest of the *sūtra*. This exemplifies that the viability of the path to Buddhahood is a premise taken for granted, in line with the bodhisattva ideal as a pan-Buddhist development.⁶⁹ The situation differs once the *ekāyāna* polemic emerges with the *Saddharmapuṇḍarīkā*.⁷⁰ Such a controversial position is

方至西方, 從西方至北方。

⁶⁷ DN 17 at DN II 172,24 and 173,14: *puratthimaṃ disaṃ pavatti ... puratthimaṃ samuddaṃ ajjhogāhetvā paccuttarivā dakkhiṇaṃ disaṃ pavatti pe dakkhiṇaṃ samuddaṃ ajjhogāhetvā paccuttarivā pacchimaṃ disaṃ pavatti pe pacchimaṃ samuddaṃ ajjhogāhetvā paccuttarivā uttaraṃ disaṃ pavatti*; DĀ 2 at T I 21c25 and 22a7: 向東方 ... 至東海表, 次行南方, 西方, 北方 and MĀ 68 at T I 514a2, which abbreviates and needs to be supplemented based on the full description given in the preceding discourse, MĀ 67 at T I 512a20+28: 向於東方 ... 過東方去, 度東大海, 迴至南方, 西方, 北方。

⁶⁸ For a discussion of such variations in *Prajñāpāramitā* literature see Lamotte 1944/1981: 25n1. Based on surveying these variations in the different versions of the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā* and mentioning the subsequent prediction by the Buddha that there will be many bodhisattvas in northern India but only few of them will study the *Prajñāpāramitā*, Karashima 2013: 180f concludes that “[t]hese descriptions apparently suggest that the text of the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā*, took shape in northern India ... it is evident from the above-stated descriptions that the text itself was composed in *Uttarāpatha* (in Chinese 北天竺 ‘northern India’) ... I assume that, in the above-quoted prophecy by the Buddha, *Uttarāpatha* is none other than the Gandhāra region.” The proposed reasoning is not entirely clear to me, as northern India is the ending point of the circular progression through different parts of India rather than its starting point, and the subsequent indication regarding the fortunes of the *Prajñāpāramitā* in the north is also not about the composition of the text but much rather about its reception; see Karashima 2011: 227,3 (= T 224 at T VIII 446b11): 北天竺亦甚多菩薩摩訶薩, 少有學般若波羅蜜者。Besides, in view of the articulations of defensiveness and anxieties in relation to its own status as *Buddhavacana* and the clear indication given at its outset that the delivery of the *Prajñāpāramitā* should be understood to have happened at Mount Vulture Peak, being spoken by the Buddha himself, it seems improbable that those involved in its formation and transmission would intentionally provide a hint that the text was instead composed somewhere else, and by implication then also by someone else, as that would directly undermine the *Prajñāpāramitā*'s status as *Buddhavacana*. In terms of the aspect of the imagery that forms the main topic of my exploration, to do so would be playing into the hands of Māra. In a general comment not related to the *Prajñāpāramitā* in particular, Allon 2024: 44 notes that, although Gāndhārī manuscripts “are our earliest manuscript witnesses to Mahayana texts, this cannot be used as evidence for a Gandharan origin for the Mahayana, since the lack of such manuscript witnesses from other parts of India may merely be due to the climate in those regions being hostile to the survival of manuscripts. Yet having said that, the Mahayana texts that lack parallels and can be shown to be Gandharan compositions certainly show that such texts were composed in Gandhara.”

⁶⁹ See Anālayo 2025d: 5–22.

⁷⁰ An example from the earliest extant version of the *Saddharmapuṇḍarīkā* translated by Dharmarakṣa would be T 263 at T IX 73a15, which conveniently combines a reference to the Buddha teaching *ekāyāna* with the threat of rebirth in hell for those who slander the *sūtra*, 若當來人, 而說此法, 聽察如來, 一乘之教, 設復覩見, 諸最勝名, 誹謗斯經, 便墮地獄。

not relevant to the *Prajñāpāramitā*, where the path to Buddhahood peacefully coexists with the path to arhat-ship, evident in the fact that the Buddha's teachings lead to attainments of stream-entry and arhat-ship among the audience of the *Prajñāpāramitā*.⁷¹ A problem only emerges when bodhisattvas attain arhat-ship, as that makes it impossible for them to become Buddhas in the future. Such a predicament find illustration with the example of a big bird that has no wings, which on trying to fly will just fall down.⁷² But apart from trying to ensure that bodhisattvas stay on the superior path they have chosen, the *Prajñāpāramitā* does not seem to have a problem with the path to arhat-ship (or Pratyekabuddhahood) in principle.

In this setting of the viability of the path to Buddhahood being taken for granted, the Buddha gives Subhūti the task of explaining the perfection of wisdom to the bodhisattvas in the assembly.⁷³ From the viewpoint of developments in Abhidharma thought that must have been present in some form in the environment within which the *Prajñāpāramitā* evolved to become the text attested in Lokakṣema's translation, Subhūti's task is—to borrow expressions from Harrison (1978: 40) and Williams (1989/2009: 50) quoted above—to oppose “the qualified realism of the prevalent Sarvāstivādins.” This calls for clarifying that all dharmas “are essentially empty (*śūnya*) and devoid of objective reality or ‘own-being’ (*svabhāva*),” thereby countering what amounts to “a defective *prajñā*, not the perfection of *prajñā*.”

In clear awareness of the practical significance of what the Buddha has asked him to expound, Subhūti does not go about his task by providing a listing of synonyms to *prajñā* or by formulating definitions. Instead, he embodies the required *prajñā* with the startling declaration that he is unable to apprehend any bodhisattva. As mentioned above, this leads to the acknowledgement of fear that may arise among the members of his audience on hearing Subhūti directly deconstruct the idea of a bodhisattva (as an ultimately existing entity endowed with an intrinsic nature). With this much established, Subhūti continues to expand on the all-pervasive nature of emptiness. This is in line with the conception of the absence of a self in *Āgama* literature, which applies to all phenomena without exception rather than being confined just to sentient beings.⁷⁴ In other words, in this respect Subhūti is, as it were, recovering and reestablishing *Āgama* teachings on emptiness.

In keeping with Subhūti's role of embodying the teaching he has been asked to give, and in contradistinction to the dry and analytical tenor of Abhidharma works, the *Prajñāpāramitā* style of teaching is populated with various celestial beings, similar to the case of *Āgama* literature, and the use of similes and narratives comes back into its own.⁷⁵ Moreover, a return to a playful attitude toward language is also evident, which already in *Āgama* literature can

⁷¹. Karashima 2011: 273,4 and 295,10 (= T 224 at T VIII 451a12 and 453b29).

⁷². Karashima 2011: 295,17 (= T 224 at T VIII 453c8).

⁷³. For a critical reply to the suggestion by Vetter 2001: 70–72 that Subhūti's role in this respect testifies to a lack of relationship between the path to Buddhahood and *prajñāpāramitā* see Anālayo 2025d: 408n759.

⁷⁴. Anālayo 2025d: 42–44.

⁷⁵. Anālayo 2025d: 67–69. The basic difference in presentation, in the words of Gethin 1998: 207, is that the discourses reflect “the application of the principles of the Buddha's teaching to a particular situation ... delivered by the Buddha, or one of his disciples, at a particular time, in a particular place, and to a particular person or group,” and such teachings can be “embellished with poetic language, with similes and metaphors that inspire the listener. The Abhidharma method, in contrast, presents the Buddha's teaching without making concessions to time or place or audience, and in technical terms that are precisely defined to ensure analytical exactitude.”

find expression in the use of paradoxical statements.⁷⁶ It is as part of this overall revival that the adoption of the *sūtra* format is a natural step to take.

Perhaps this adoption by the *Prajñāpāramitā* reflects awareness of an antecedent in some other early Mahāyāna *sūtra*. But even if this step was taken without such awareness—be this due to geographical separation from already existing specimen(s) of this type or due to being composed earlier than other such instances—this step in itself must have been almost unavoidable. In order to achieve what the *Prajñāpāramitā* is trying to achieve, in particular weaning bodhisattvas in the audience from Abhidharma influences and recovering the content and mode of teaching evident in *Āgama* literature, it would hardly work for Subhūti to embody what he is trying to convey through reliance on an Abhidharma-style type of exposition.

Besides, adopting the *sūtra* format to express a novel teaching is not without antecedents. At an early stage, Abhidharma thought developed in the form of a commentary on the discourses. This is fairly evident with the *Saṅgītiparyāya* of the Sarvāstivādins and the *Vibhaṅga* of the Theravādins.⁷⁷ In line with a general tendency of commentaries to exert an influence on the text on which they comment,⁷⁸ at times evolving Abhidharma thought expresses itself in the *sūtra* format. An example is a Pāli discourse in the *Majjhima-nikāya* that adopts a supramundane version of the first five factors of the noble eightfold path.⁷⁹ This presentation, which lacks support from its Chinese and Tibetan parallels, is clearly an addition that serves to articulate and authenticate a Theravāda Abhidharma perspective. An example from the *Madhyama-āgama* transmitted by Sarvāstivāda reciters takes the form of adding a listing of types of arhats recognized in Sarvāstivāda Abhidharma thought to a discourse, an addition that lacks support from the Pāli parallel.⁸⁰ This, too, is clearly an addition that in this case articulates and authenticates a Sarvāstivāda Abhidharma perspective. Dharmaguptaka reciters of the *Dīrgha-āgama* created a whole discourse to collect ideas on cosmology, with the resultant exposition becoming the longest text in *Āgama* literature.⁸¹ In other words, the basic procedure of promoting new perspectives by presenting them in the *sūtra* format, and thereby as spoken by the Buddha, was already in place.

With the above I am not intending to turn a blind eye to the obvious dimension of authentication that comes with adopting the *sūtra* format, in particular when the main thrust of the teachings finds articulation in an environment where adverse reactions can be expected. As mentioned above, the *Prajñāpāramitā* shows clear signs that authentication was a serious concern, wherefore my intention is decidedly not to exempt this text from the eloquent assessment by Boucher (2025: 61) of a general pattern, where “[t]he textual anxiety

^{76.} Anālayo 2027.

^{77.} Anālayo 2014a: 86–89.

^{78.} Anālayo 2022: 143–151.

^{79.} The supramundane expositions occur in MN 117 at MN III 72,16, 73,11, 74,6, 74,32, and 75,22; see Anālayo 2014a: 129–142.

^{80.} MĀ 127 at T I 616a17, whose first part parallels AN 2.4.4 at AN I 62,33, whereas the remainder corresponds to *Abhidharmakośavyākhyā*, Wogihara 1936: 566,25, introduced as a *sūtra* quotation that must be intending a version of MĀ 127.

^{81.} DĀ 30 at T I 114b7 to 149c21; see the discussion in Anālayo 2014c: 35–44. The qualification of being the longest discourse in *Āgama* literature concerns the actual length of other discourses; the situation would change if abbreviations were to be executed in full, in which case the last discourse in the *Madhyama-āgama*, MĀ 222, would become the longest discourse in *Āgama* literature; see Anālayo 2014a: 44–47.

that dominates Mahāyāna literature generates a nostalgia for orality and the authenticity born of being ‘present’ before buddhas who guarantee it.” My point is only that authentication and such nostalgia need not be an exhaustive account of the set of conditions informing the adoption of the *sūtra* format. Said differently, such adoption can additionally also function as an integral part of the main message of the *Prajñāpāramitā*.

Conclusion

A survey of the roles of Māra in early Mahāyāna *sūtras* extant in Chinese translation from the Eastern Han period shows different dimensions of his gradual acculturation to a Mahāyāna context. The same survey results in providing a spotlight on the prominence of his function in articulating anxieties in the *Prajñāpāramitā* extant as T 224. Anxieties in relation to the reception of the rhetoric of emptiness also feature in the same text apart from any relationship to Māra, related to the *Prajñāpāramitā*’s voicing criticism of Abhidharma theories advocating *svabhāva*. The adoption of the *sūtra* format by the *Prajñāpāramitā* can in turn be seen as an integral part of its overall message rather than being solely motivated by the needs of authentication.

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Appendix: A Note on the Original Language of the *Prajñāpāramitā*

Paul Harrison

Speculation about where and in what language the first *Prajñāpāramitā* texts were written has a long history. This is not the place to review the considerable scholarship on this topic, except to point out that it has usually included some consideration of the tradition that branches of the Mahāsāṃghikas transmitted a *Prajñāpāramitā*, as well as other Mahāyāna *sūtras*, in Prakrit and of the fact that the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā* itself includes in its 10th chapter an account of its movement around India in a kind of triumphal progress which takes off from the south before proceeding, either by the west or by the east, to end up in the north, where it is prophesied to flourish (the implicit point of origin is presumably on the Vulture Peak in Magadha, counted either as east or center). While some scholars have been disinclined to accept that this *pradakṣiṇa* account has any historical value, seeing it as a purely ritual flourish, many have found the emphasis on the fortunes of the teaching in the north much more compelling. Recently others, like Falk and Karashima, have gone further and even speculated—albeit tentatively—that the language of the early *Prajñāpāramitā* might have been Gāndhārī (see Falk and Karashima 2012: 20; Karashima 2013), the recent explosion of Gāndhārī Studies seemingly giving us a new lens through which to look at this question.

There is no denying that we now have Gāndhārī fragments from two chapters of the text we generally refer to as the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā* and that it is also quite likely, as Karashima has demonstrated (2013: 174–179), that Lokakṣema’s pioneering Chinese translation of the work in 179 CE was made from a Gāndhārī Vorlage. However, this does not necessarily mean that the *Short Prajñāpāramitā*—better to call it this than the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā*, which is anachronistic—was initially composed in Gāndhārī. Indeed, there are grounds for believing that the Gāndhārī version was a translation—or perhaps better, linguistic transposition—from another Middle Indic Prakrit, and this for the simple reason that the text contains a number of puns or plays on words (*śleṣas*) which do not work in Gāndhārī any better than they do in Classical Sanskrit. Many of these are clustered in Chapter 1, the most telling example being the explanation of the meaning of the term *bodhisattva* involving a play on two words which are in Sanskrit *sattva* and *sakta*. In Pāli, as is well known, these two words are both *satta*, which means the pun would work perfectly in Pāli. In Gāndhārī, however, *sattva* is *satva*, so if the Gāndhārī equivalent of *sakta* is *sata* (unattested to my knowledge, but likely given that *mukta* is *muta*, *ukta* is *vuta*, and *yukta* is *yuta*), the pun is lost, as it is in the Sanskrit text we now have. The same goes for the explanations offered of the term *mahāsattva*, of which there are several. The relevant question-and-answer sequence can be found in Lokakṣema’s translation at T 224, 8: 427b11–28. The match with the Sanskrit text (Mitra’s edition, 17–19; Vaidya’s edition, 9.20–10.12) is not exact, but the term *wusuo zhuo* 無所著 (here corresponding to Sanskrit *asakta*, *asaktatā*) occurs four times, indicating that the play on *sattva* and *sakta* is being made to carry some weight.

Of course it is highly unlikely that the *Short Prajñāpāramitā* was originally composed in Pāli, but there may have been other Prakrits in use in different parts of India which could be candidates, sharing some of Pāli’s linguistic features. One of them is the language in which the *Lokānuvartanā-sūtra* was written, a text cited several times by Candrakīrti in a number of his works in its original Prakrit form and referred to by him as the *gāthās* of the Pūrvaśailānikāya. This sūtra provides a classic statement of the Lokottaravāda doctrine for which the Mahāsāṃghikas are so well known, at the same time sounding many notes consistent with a Prajñāpāramitā take on Buddhist teachings. In Candrakīrti’s citations *sattva* always appears as *satta*. Although the past participle *sakta* is unfortunately not attested in the few verses surviving in their Indic form, these verses do appear to offer tantalizing clues, hitherto unconsidered, as to the kind of Prakrit in which the Perfection of Wisdom may have been first formulated. (A full study of the *Lokānuvartanā* is currently in preparation, in which I will consider these issues in detail.)

This is, to be sure, only a cursory note on a small part of the evidence, and there is much more work to be done—including a systematic review of all the *śleṣas* buried just below the surface of the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā*’s Sanskrit text. Yet it should be enough to make us rethink the tradition about a Prakrit Prajñāpāramitā transmitted by the Mahāsāṃghikas and the testimony of the *Short Prajñāpāramitā* itself about its geographical spread. At the very least it should make us cautious about rushing to Gandhāra to locate the origins of the Perfection of Wisdom, even if we accept that Gandhāra later became one of its strongholds—or, to invoke the botanical metaphor of the title of one of the Venerable Anālayo’s recent books, provided the fertile soil in which, once transplanted from elsewhere, it bloomed so profusely.

Abbreviations

AN	<i>Aṅguttara-nikāya</i>
CBETA	Chinese Buddhist Electronic Text Association
DĀ	<i>Dīrgha-āgama</i> (T 1)
DN	<i>Dīgha-nikāya</i>
EĀ	<i>Ekottarika-āgama</i> (T 125)
EĀ ²	<i>Ekottarika-āgama</i> (T 150A)
MĀ	<i>Madhyama-āgama</i> (T 26)
MN	<i>Majjhima-nikāya</i>
PTS	Pali Text Society
SĀ	<i>Samyukta-āgama</i> (T 99)
SĀ ²	<i>Samyukta-āgama</i> (T 100)
SĀ ³	<i>Samyukta-āgama</i> (T 101)
SHT	Sanskrithandschrift aus den Turfanfunden
SN	<i>Samyutta-nikāya</i>
T	Taishō (CBETA)
Vin	<i>Vinaya</i>

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